front matter

preface

In the beginning, there was Active Server Pages (ASP)—a page-focused web development framework from Microsoft that enabled developers to build interactive web applications that could process form submissions and communicate with databases. The development model was a simple one: each page in a website was represented by a single file, which had a name and path that shared a one-to-one mapping with the URL for the page. Each file consisted of a mixture of HTML and a scripting language that executed on the web server to generate more HTML. However, as the complexity of an individual page grew, so did its content—often resulting in difficult-to-maintain *spaghetti code*. Scripting languages lacked any type checking, which easily led to the introduction of bugs that were only discovered at run time.

Then came ASP.NET Web Forms—another page-focused web development framework. By supporting the strongly typed C# and VB.NET languages, Web Forms offered compile-time code checking, resulting in fewer bugs finding their way to the production server. It also offered a separation between the page's presentation and its behavior with the introduction of the code-behind file, reducing the amount of spaghetti code. On the downside, basic HTTP technologies were abstracted away by the Web Forms development experience, which tried to emulate that of VB6 desktop application developers. The UI was composed of *server controls*, which the developer could drag and drop onto a design surface. These controls were responsible for generating HTML, which wasn't always accessible or